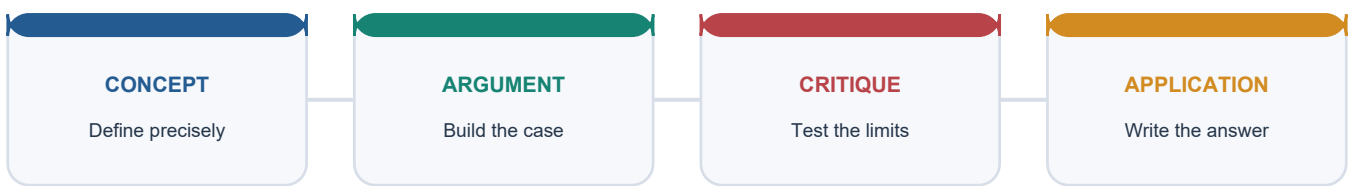


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Mīmāṃsā - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Mīmāṃsā - Solved Practice Workbook	3
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	3
Practice protocol	3
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	19
VERIFIED PREVIOUS-YEAR QUESTIONS - 14 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS	19
ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE	28

Mīmāṃsā - Solved Practice Workbook

How to use this workbook. Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed independently for each question from a randomised draw, so no rotation or predictable sequence can be exploited. Every option carries a question-specific explanation and every question carries a unique examiner trap. The solved previous-year questions reproduce the official printed wording exactly; the model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.

Contents. 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial drills, then 14 solved previous-year questions - every part primary-owned by syllabus item 18 across 2018-2025 - followed by six original solved Mains models at 2 x 10, 2 x 15 and 2 x 20 marks.

Declared answer bands. 10 marks: 150-200 words. 15 marks: 250-300 words. 20 marks: 340-400 words. Every solved answer below states its exact word count.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct position was fixed **independently for each question** from a randomised draw, so there is no rotation, cycle or seed-derived sequence to exploit; the four positions occur eight times each and twice in every consecutive block of eight, no position repeats on consecutive questions, and no window of four items forms an A->B->C->D rotation or an ABAB alternation. Option length, specificity, grammar and formatting are balanced so that the correct answer is not visually identifiable. Every option carries a question-specific explanation and every question carries a unique examiner trap.

Composition: 24 core diagnostics (items 1-24) covering all nineteen teaching sessions, then 8 remedial drills (items 25-32) targeting the errors this topic reliably produces.

CORE DIAGNOSTICS

MCQ 1. What Mīmāṃsā's theory of knowledge is for

Which statement best expresses why Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā develops a theory of knowledge at all?

A. Because it inherits Sāṃkhya's instruments and must justify the count it has already accepted B. Because duty is supersensible, so testimony alone reaches it and must itself be made secure C. Because it treats speculative theology as prior to ritual and needs a metaphysics of being D. Because it aims to refute Cārvāka materialism before any positive doctrine can be advanced

Answer: B. Because duty is supersensible, so testimony alone reaches it and must itself be made secure

- **A:** Mīmāṃsā's list is longer than Sāṃkhya's, not inherited from it, and the count is defended by an irreducibility test rather than adopted first and rationalised afterwards.
- **B:** Correct - Jaimini's inquiry into duty defines duty by Vedic injunction, and because injunction is the only competent instrument for a supersensible object, its authority forces a general theory of cognition.
- **C:** The school is explicitly action-guiding rather than speculative-theological, and its metaphysics is deliberately minimal, supplying only what the epistemology and ritual theory require.
- **D:** The Cārvāka exchange is a genuine front for the school, but it is a consequence of the position rather than the motive that generates the epistemology in the first place.

Examiner trap 1: Candidates who learn the doctrines as a list cannot say why the list exists, and they lose the framing sentence that makes every later paragraph look purposeful rather than assembled.

MCQ 2. Lineage and the ownership boundary

Consider the following statements about the Mīmāṃsā textual tradition.

1. Śabara's commentary is the foundational surviving exposition of Jaimini's aphorisms.
2. Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā owns injunction, duty, authorless verbal authority and ritual interpretation.
3. Śālikanātha is a major later expositor of the Bhāṭṭa line founded by Kumārila.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statements 1 and 3 only, since the commentarial ladder runs from Śabara through Śālikanātha B. Statement 2 only, because textual attribution in this school is too disputed to be asserted C. Statements 1 and 2 only, as Śālikanātha belongs to the Prābhākara rather than the Bhāṭṭa line D. All three statements, because ownership and lineage are jointly settled by the same tradition

Answer: C. Statements 1 and 2 only, as Śālikanātha belongs to the Prābhākara rather than the Bhāṭṭa line

- **A:** Keeps the true first statement but carries the misattribution in the third, and the resulting "ladder" runs through two lines that the tradition keeps separate.
- **B:** Over-corrects: the doctrinal ownership boundary and the identity of the foundational commentary are both securely held, and only fine chronology is genuinely disputed.
- **C:** Correct - Śabara's *Śābara-bhāṣya* is foundational, the four owned items belong to the earlier inquiry, and Śālikanātha expounds Prābhākara, not Kumārila.
- **D:** Accepts the misattribution of Śālikanātha, and treats disputed relative chronology as though it were settled alongside doctrinal ownership.

Examiner trap 2: Because both sub-schools descend from the same two-stage base, candidates assume any later name may be attached to either line, and Śālikanātha is the name this habit most often misplaces.

MCQ 3. Reading the Bhāṭṭa-Prābhākara grid

Which row correctly pairs a Bhāṭṭa position with the corresponding Prābhākara position?

A. Six instruments and real absence, against five instruments and the bare unqualified locus B. Self-luminous cognition and knownness, against inferred cognition and threefold awareness C. Non-discrimination in error and word-priority, against contrary apprehension and sentence-priority D. Categorical obligation and five instruments, against fruit-motivation and independent absence

Answer: A. Six instruments and real absence, against five instruments and the bare unqualified locus

- **A:** Correct - Kumārila admits non-cognition as a sixth instrument and treats absence as real with a counterpositive, while Prābhākara declines both and perceives the locus as unqualified.
- **B:** Reverses the pairing twice over: self-luminosity and threefold awareness are Prābhākara, while knownness and inferred cognition are Bhāṭṭa.
- **C:** Reverses both halves: non-discrimination is Prābhākara and contrary apprehension Bhāṭṭa, and word-priority is Bhāṭṭa while sentence-priority is Prābhākara.
- **D:** Attaches categorical obligation and the five-instrument list to Bhāṭṭa, when obligation-based motivation and the shorter list both belong to Prābhākara.

Examiner trap 3: The six paired differences are learned as isolated facts rather than as one methodological instinct applied six times, so a candidate who misremembers one row usually misremembers the rest in the same direction.

MCQ 4. The fourfold formulation of validity

Which statement gives the Mīmāṃsā position on all four cells of the validity question?

A. Validity is intrinsic in origin and extrinsic in ascertainment; invalidity is extrinsic in both B. Validity and invalidity are both intrinsic in origin, and both are ascertained extrinsically C. Validity is intrinsic in origin and in ascertainment; invalidity is extrinsic in both respects D. Validity is extrinsic in origin and intrinsic in ascertainment; invalidity reverses that pattern

Answer: C. Validity is intrinsic in origin and in ascertainment; invalidity is extrinsic in both respects

- **A:** Splits validity across the two cells, which would reintroduce exactly the external certifier that the school's anti-regress argument was designed to eliminate.
- **B:** Makes invalidity intrinsic in origin, which is the Sāṃkhya placement rather than the Mīmāṃsā one and would require falsity to announce itself at birth.
- **C:** Correct - the same conditions that generate the cognition generate its validity, the cognition presents itself as trustworthy unaided, and falsity requires a defect and a defeater.
- **D:** Assigns extrinsic origin to validity, which is the Nyāya thesis, and then adds an intrinsic ascertainment that no school in the standard grid actually holds.

Examiner trap 4: Answers state only that "validity is intrinsic" and omit the invalidity row, so they cannot explain error and forfeit the comparison the 2025 question is built on.

MCQ 5. What intrinsic validity does not claim

Identify the sentence that a Mīmāṃsaka would refuse to endorse.

A. A cognition carries authority on arrival and loses it only when a defeating condition appears B. Every cognition is indefeasible, so a cognition once had can never afterwards be surrendered C. The burden of proof lies on the challenger of a cognition rather than on the cognition itself D. Falsity is caused by defect and becomes known through contradiction, failure or later correction

Answer: B. Every cognition is indefeasible, so a cognition once had can never afterwards be surrendered

- **A:** This is the school's thesis in its ordinary formulation, and the phrase "defeating condition" is the standard marker of its defeasibility.
- **B:** Correct as the sentence to reject - intrinsic validity is defeasible default warrant, and the school explicitly distinguishes default validity from guaranteed incorrigibility.
- **C:** The burden-shift is precisely what the anti-regress argument establishes, and the school appeals to lived practice to support it.
- **D:** This states the extrinsic invalidity half of the doctrine accurately, including both the causal defect and the routes by which falsity is detected.

Examiner trap 5: The word "intrinsic" is read as "infallible," and the resulting answer cannot survive the dream-and-mirage objection that every examiner in this area expects to see handled.

MCQ 6. Nyāya's route and the Mīmāṃsā counter

Which pairing correctly states a Nyāya method of validation together with the Mīmāṃsā objection to it?

A. Successful activity, objected to on the ground that action never in fact confirms anything B. Confirming perception, objected to on the ground that perception is inherently untrustworthy C. Divine testimony, objected to on the ground that scripture cannot certify ordinary cognitions D. Successful activity, objected to on the ground that acting already presupposes trusting it

Answer: D. Successful activity, objected to on the ground that acting already presupposes trusting it

- **A:** Mīmāṃsā never denies that action can confirm; it denies only that confirmation *generates* the validity the cognition already possessed.
- **B:** The school is a robust perceptual realist, so an objection resting on the untrustworthiness of perception could not be its own.
- **C:** Divine testimony is not one of the two classical Nyāya routes to validation, which are successful activity and confirming perception.
- **D:** Correct - one must act before one is entitled to trust, but the action itself relies on trust, so Nyāya uses what it officially postpones.

Examiner trap 6: Only one of Nyāya's two routes is remembered, and the answer then fails to show that the regress objection applies to confirming perception exactly as it applies to successful activity.

MCQ 7. Placing four schools on validity and invalidity

Match each school with its standard placement on the intrinsic/extrinsic question.

School	Placement
1. Mīmāṃsā	P. validity extrinsic, invalidity intrinsic
2. Sāṃkhya	Q. validity intrinsic, invalidity extrinsic
3. Buddhist epistemology	R. validity intrinsic, invalidity intrinsic

A. 1-Q, 2-R, 3-P B. 1-R, 2-Q, 3-P C. 1-Q, 2-P, 3-R D. 1-P, 2-R, 3-Q

Answer: A. 1-Q, 2-R, 3-P

- **A:** Correct - Mīmāṃsā holds intrinsic validity with extrinsic invalidity, Sāṃkhya is presented as intrinsic on both, and the Buddhist placement is the exact mirror-image.
- **B:** Gives Mīmāṃsā the Sāṃkhya cell, which would commit the school to falsity announcing itself at the moment of cognition.
- **C:** Assigns the Buddhist cell to Sāṃkhya and the Sāṃkhya cell to Buddhism, reversing the two schools whose placements are most often swapped.
- **D:** Gives Mīmāṃsā the Buddhist cell, which contradicts the school's central thesis and its whole strategy against scepticism.

Examiner trap 7: Sāṃkhya and Buddhism are remembered only as "the other two," and because their placements are adjacent in every table they are routinely exchanged under time pressure.

MCQ 8. Counting the instruments, and the rule behind the count

Consider the following statements about the Mīmāṃsā list of instruments of valid knowledge.

1. Bhāṭṭa accepts six and Prābhākara five, and the difference concerns non-cognition.
2. An instrument is admitted only where reduction to another fails without remainder or circularity.
3. Memory is excluded from both lists because it fails the requirement of novelty.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statements 1 and 3 only, because the admission rule is Nyāya's rather than Mīmāṃsā's B. Statement 1 only, since novelty is a Nyāya condition that Mīmāṃsā does not itself impose C. Statements 2 and 3 only, as both sub-schools in fact accept the same number of instruments D. All three statements, since the same admission rule both licenses and restricts the list

Answer: D. All three statements, since the same admission rule both licenses and restricts the list

- **A:** Denies the school's own irreducibility principle, which is exactly what Mīmāṃsā invokes to justify admitting postulation and non-cognition.
- **B:** Nyāya does accept the novelty requirement, but so does Mīmāṃsā, and Prābhākara's five-step argument against memory turns on it directly.
- **C:** Contradicts the single most-tested numerical fact in this topic, since the two sub-schools differ precisely by one instrument.
- **D:** Correct - the irreducibility rule admits postulation and non-cognition, and the same rule excludes memory, which reproduces rather than produces cognition.

Examiner trap 8: The counts are memorised without the rule, so the candidate can state that Bhāṭṭa has six but cannot explain why six is principled rather than arbitrary.

MCQ 9. Comparison, stated in Mīmāṃsā's own form

A learner writes: "In Mīmāṃsā, comparison is the instrument by which one learns, from a reliable person's statement that a wild ox resembles a cow, what the word 'wild ox' denotes." What is the correct assessment of this sentence?

A. It is accurate, because Mīmāṃsā and Nyāya give identical accounts of comparison in every respect B. It is inaccurate, because it states the Nyāya word-reference account instead of the Mīmāṃsā one C. It is inaccurate, because Mīmāṃsā does not accept comparison as an independent instrument at all D. It is accurate, because comparison in Mīmāṃsā is defined through prior testimony about similarity

Answer: B. It is inaccurate, because it states the Nyāya word-reference account instead of the Mīmāṃsā one

- **A:** The two accounts are expressly distinguished, and treating them as identical erases the very contrast the sources use to define the Mīmāṃsā instrument.
- **B:** Correct - in Mīmāṃsā the new cognition is that the previously seen, presently absent cow is similar to this perceived wild ox, and no word-learning is involved.
- **C:** Comparison is accepted by both sub-schools and appears in both the five-item and the six-item lists, so the denial is simply false.
- **D:** Reproduces the same Nyāya mechanism under a different description, since prior testimony about similarity is precisely what Mīmāṃsā's account does not require.

Examiner trap 9: The wild-ox example is shared by both schools while the mechanism is not, so a candidate who remembers only the example imports the wrong account without noticing.

MCQ 10. Perception and testimony, correctly divided

Which statement about perception and testimony in Mīmāṃsā is correct?

A. Determinate perception falsifies the given, so realism must be defended by inference instead B. Testimony is admitted only where perception and inference have already been tried and failed C. Impersonal testimony depends on a divine speaker whose omniscience secures the Vedic text D. Determinate perception interprets what the indeterminate stage held, and Vedic testimony is impersonal

Answer: D. Determinate perception interprets what the indeterminate stage held, and Vedic testimony is impersonal

- **A:** Reverses the school's realism: the determinate stage unpacks what was implicitly available and does not invent an unreal predicate.
- **B:** Testimony is not a fallback here; for supersensible duty it is the only competent instrument, and the school gives it a corresponding dignity.
- **C:** Assigns the Nyāya God-guarantee to Mīmāṃsā, whereas impersonal testimony is authoritative precisely because it has no speaker at all.
- **D:** Correct - the two-stage account supports realism against the bare-particular reading, and Vedic testimony is impersonal rather than divinely authored.

Examiner trap 10: Candidates treat "impersonal" as a synonym for "divine," and the resulting answer quietly converts Mīmāṃsā into the Nyāya position it was constructed to avoid.

MCQ 11. Why memory is refused instrument-status

On what precise ground do the Prābhākaras and the Naiyāyikas both deny that memory is a means of valid knowledge?

A. Memory is frequently mistaken, and an instrument may not be liable to systematic error B. Memory has no object, since a past object is no longer available to be presented at all C. Memory reproduces already-cognised content and so fails the requirement of fresh disclosure D. Memory belongs to the internal organ rather than to the senses, and only sense-instruments qualify

Answer: C. Memory reproduces already-cognised content and so fails the requirement of fresh disclosure

- **A:** The exclusion is definitional rather than evaluative, and the school concedes that memory may be perfectly true and reliably action-guiding.
- **B:** Memory does have an object; the difficulty is that the object was already disclosed, not that it is missing from the cognition.
- **C:** Correct - an instrument must generate a new cognition, whereas memory depends on an earlier cognition and its latent impression and merely re-presents.
- **D:** Introduces a faculty-location criterion that neither school uses, and would wrongly exclude inference and testimony along with memory.

Examiner trap 11: "Memory is unreliable" is offered as the reason, which both concedes too much to the sceptic and misses the novelty condition the question is testing.

MCQ 12. The structure of postulation

Which sequence correctly reproduces the canonical postulation case?

A. Devadatta is stout; stoutness invariably accompanies eating; therefore Devadatta eats at night B. Devadatta is stout and does not eat by day; the two cannot stand together; therefore he eats at night C. Devadatta does not eat by day; night-eating is remembered from an earlier occasion; therefore he eats at night D. Devadatta is stout; a reliable witness reports night-eating; therefore the report is accepted as true

Answer: B. Devadatta is stout and does not eat by day; the two cannot stand together; therefore he eats at night

- **A:** Supplies a universal concomitance and thereby converts the case into an inference, which is exactly the Nyāya reduction the school rejects as circular.
- **B:** Correct - two accepted facts generate explanatory tension and the minimally reconciling postulate resolves it, with no prior concomitance and no sign.
- **C:** Makes the conclusion a recollection, whereas the whole point of the case is that night-eating is neither perceived nor remembered here.
- **D:** Turns the case into testimony, which would make the third fact reported rather than postulated and would remove the tension that drives the cognition.

Examiner trap 12: The case is retold with an added premise such as "whoever is fat eats," which silently concedes the Nyāya reduction the answer was supposed to refute.

MCQ 13. Why postulation is not inference

Which of the following is *not* one of the three arguments Mīmāṃsā gives against reducing postulation to inference?

A. Postulation is unreliable, since a postulated fact is never confirmed by later observation B. No universal concomitance is independently established before the postulating cognition arises C. The movement runs from explanatory tension to a reconciling postulate rather than from sign to signified D. The case cannot be parsed into a subject, a reason present in it, and a probandum derived from it

Answer: A. Postulation is unreliable, since a postulated fact is never confirmed by later observation

- **A:** Correct as the odd one out - the school never argues from unreliability, and its claim is that the postulate is *necessary*, not that it is unverified.
- **B:** This is the first argument: inference requires a concomitance known beforehand, and no such rule about stout day-fasters is available.
- **C:** This is the second argument, which contrasts the direction of reasoning in the two instruments and is the easiest of the three to state.
- **D:** This is the third argument, which denies that the case exhibits the subject-reason-probandum form that standard inference requires.

Examiner trap 13: Only one anti-reduction argument is offered, usually the concomitance point, and the answer then has nothing left to say when the examiner's directive asks for a critical discussion.

MCQ 14. The fitness condition on non-cognition

Which case satisfies the conditions under which non-apprehension yields knowledge of absence?

A. Failing to see the keys on a cluttered desk in poor light after a hurried glance at it B. Failing to detect atoms in the space directly in front of one's own functioning eyes C. Failing to hear a sound while attention is wholly absorbed in an unrelated conversation D. Failing to see a pot on a bare, well-lit table placed at normal distance before the eyes

Answer: D. Failing to see a pot on a bare, well-lit table placed at normal distance before the eyes

- **A:** Poor light and a hurried glance are exactly the conditions the fitness requirement excludes, so this is careless overlooking rather than a cognition of absence.
- **B:** Atoms are not the kind of thing that would be perceived if present, so the first and most basic fitness condition fails at once.
- **C:** Absorbed attention breaks the condition that attention be proper, which is why inattentive non-hearing discloses nothing about the sound.
- **D:** Correct - the object is perceptible in kind, the locus is suitable, the organ functions and light, distance and attention are all proper.

Examiner trap 14: The fitness condition is omitted altogether, leaving the doctrine indistinguishable from an argument from ignorance and defenceless against the charge of subjectivism.

MCQ 15. The three-way dispute about absence

Which statement correctly reports the positions of Bhāṭṭa, Prābhākara and Nyāya on absence?

A. Bhāṭṭa admits a separate instrument, Prābhākara perceives the bare locus, Nyāya perceives absence B. Bhāṭṭa perceives absence directly, Prābhākara admits a separate instrument, Nyāya denies absence C. All three admit absence as real but only Nyāya admits a separate instrument for knowing it D. Bhāṭṭa and Nyāya converge on a separate instrument while Prābhākara reduces absence to inference

Answer: A. Bhāṭṭa admits a separate instrument, Prābhākara perceives the bare locus, Nyāya perceives absence

- **A:** Correct - Kumārila admits non-cognition, Prābhākara perceives the locus as unqualified, and Nyāya accepts absence as a real category directly perceived.
- **B:** Reverses Bhāṭṭa and Prābhākara and then adds the false claim that Nyāya denies absence, when Nyāya denies only the separate instrument.
- **C:** Attributes the separate instrument to Nyāya, which is precisely the school that argues absence is available to perception without one.
- **D:** Invents a Bhāṭṭa-Nyāya convergence, whereas the actual convergence is between Nyāya and Prābhākara against Bhāṭṭa on independence.

Examiner trap 15: "Nyāya rejects non-cognition" is compressed into "Nyāya rejects absence," which misrepresents a school that treats absence as one of its own categories.

MCQ 16. The four theories of error

Match each theory of error with the account it gives of the shell-silver case.

Theory	Account
1. akhyāti / vivekākhyāti	P. real silver known elsewhere is presented here
2. viparīta-khyāti	Q. two valid cognitions whose difference is not apprehended
3. anyathā-khyāti	R. the shell is positively miscognised as silver

A. 1-P, 2-Q, 3-R B. 1-R, 2-P, 3-Q C. 1-Q, 2-R, 3-P D. 1-Q, 2-P, 3-R

Answer: C. 1-Q, 2-R, 3-P

- **A:** Gives Prābhākara the Nyāya displacement account and Nyāya the Bhāṭṭa misidentification account, inverting the two theories most often confused.
- **B:** Assigns misidentification to Prābhākara, who admits no false cognition at all, and non-discrimination to Nyāya, which never uses it.
- **C:** Correct - non-discrimination is Prābhākara, contrary apprehension is Bhāṭṭa's positive misidentification, and displacement of real silver is Nyāya.
- **D:** Correctly places Prābhākara but then exchanges Bhāṭṭa and Nyāya, which is the single most damaging slip available in this area.

Examiner trap 16: Bhāṭṭa's contrary apprehension and Nyāya's displacement are both described loosely as "a false cognition," and the distinction between misidentifying this object and misplacing another is lost.

MCQ 17. Why two schools that share a thesis still divide on error

Both Bhāṭṭa and Prābhākara accept the intrinsic validity of knowledge. Which statement best explains why they nevertheless divide over erroneous cognition?

A. They divide because Prābhākara abandons intrinsic validity whenever illusion is under discussion B. They divide because Bhāṭṭa treats falsity as intrinsic while Prābhākara treats it as extrinsic C. They divide because only Bhāṭṭa accepts that illusion produces any action at all in the subject D. They divide because each protects the shared thesis differently - constituents versus the principle

Answer: D. They divide because each protects the shared thesis differently - constituents versus the principle

- **A:** Prābhākara never suspends the thesis; his whole strategy is designed so that no constituent cognition ever has to be called false.
- **B:** Both hold falsity to be extrinsic in origin, and intrinsic falsity is the standard Buddhist placement rather than anything Kumārila accepts.
- **C:** Both must explain the reaching behaviour, and the disagreement is over what explains it, not over whether it occurs.
- **D:** Correct - Prābhākara keeps every constituent cognition valid, while Kumārila keeps the principle governing normal cognition and quarantines falsity in defect.

Examiner trap 17: The "in spite of" clause is treated as scene-setting rather than as the question, and the answer describes two error-theories without ever explaining their compatibility with one shared thesis.

MCQ 18. Three answers to "how do I know that I know?"

Which option correctly assigns each mechanism to its school?

A. Threefold awareness to Prābhākara, knownness to Bhāṭṭa, after-cognition to Nyāya B. Threefold awareness to Bhāṭṭa, knownness to Nyāya, after-cognition to Prābhākara C. Threefold awareness to Nyāya, knownness to Prābhākara, after-cognition to Bhāṭṭa D. Threefold awareness to Prābhākara, knownness to Nyāya, after-cognition to Bhāṭṭa

Answer: A. Threefold awareness to Prābhākara, knownness to Bhāṭṭa, after-cognition to Nyāya

- **A:** Correct - Prābhākara's single act discloses knower, known and knowing; Kumārila infers cognition from the object's knownness; Nyāya posits a distinct second-order act.
- **B:** Moves every mechanism one place, giving Prābhākara the second-order act he expressly rejects because it would restart the regress.
- **C:** Makes Nyāya a defender of self-luminosity, when Nyāya is the school that denies it and supplies a higher-order cognition instead.
- **D:** Retains the correct Prābhākara assignment but exchanges Bhāṭṭa and Nyāya, which are the two non-self-luminous positions and therefore easiest to confuse.

Examiner trap 18: The three views are listed without naming the regress they all answer, so the response reads as an inventory of opinions rather than as three engineered solutions to one problem.

MCQ 19. Self-luminosity and intrinsic validity

Which school provides the decisive counterexample to the claim that self-luminosity necessarily entails intrinsic validity?

A. Nyāya, because it accepts self-luminosity while denying that validity can be intrinsic B. Advaita Vedānta, because it restricts self-luminosity to the empirical level of reality C. Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā, because it accepts self-luminosity but denies intrinsic validity D. Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā, because it denies self-luminosity while affirming intrinsic validity

Answer: D. Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā, because it denies self-luminosity while affirming intrinsic validity

- **A:** Nyāya denies self-luminosity as well as intrinsic validity, so it accepts neither thesis and cannot serve as a counterexample to an entailment between them.
- **B:** Advaita affirms both, grounding self-luminosity in consciousness as such, so it illustrates the pairing rather than breaking it.
- **C:** Prābhākara affirms both theses together, which is exactly the combination the entailment-claim predicts and therefore proves nothing against it.
- **D:** Correct - Kumārila holds intrinsic validity while inferring cognition from acquired knownness, showing that the two doctrines come apart in practice.

Examiner trap 19: Nyāya is placed in the "self-luminous but extrinsically valid" cell, which destroys the comparative grid the 2018 question is entirely built upon.

MCQ 20. Sentence-unity and the two semantics

Consider the following statements about Mīmāṃsā philosophy of language.

1. Expectancy, semantic fitness and proximity are accepted by both sub-schools.
2. Connection-of-the-already-denoted is the Prābhākara thesis about sentence meaning.
3. Purport, added by Naiyāyikas, is difficult for Mīmāṃsā because the Veda has no author.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statements 1 and 2 only, because the two sub-schools agree entirely on sentence meaning B. Statement 2 only, because the three conditions belong to Nyāya rather than to Mīmāṃsā C. Statements 1 and 3 only, since connection-of-the-already-denoted is in fact the Bhāṭṭa thesis D. All three statements, since both sub-schools share the conditions and both accept purport

Answer: C. Statements 1 and 3 only, since connection-of-the-already-denoted is in fact the Bhāṭṭa thesis

- **A:** Keeps the misattribution and adds the false claim of agreement, when the two sub-schools differ precisely over which unit is semantically primary.
- **B:** Denies the three shared conditions to Mīmāṃsā, although both sub-schools invoke them to explain how a word-sequence becomes one sentence.
- **C:** Correct - the three conditions are shared, purport is a genuine difficulty for an authorless text, and word-priority belongs to Bhāṭṭa.
- **D:** Mīmāṃsā cannot simply accept purport as speaker-intention, and it must relocate purport into textual function and subordination to injunction.

Examiner trap 20: The two long compound labels are learned by sound rather than by sense, and the connected-denotation thesis is handed to the sub-school that actually denies it.

MCQ 21. Universals, particulars and the exclusion challenge

Which statement correctly represents the Mīmāṃsā position on what words denote?

A. Words denote the universal primarily, and the individual is reached through it in context B. Words denote the individual primarily, with the universal serving only as its qualifier C. Words denote neither, since generality is produced by excluding what the word does not apply to D. Words denote an indivisible sentence-entity in which universal and individual are undivided

Answer: A. Words denote the universal primarily, and the individual is reached through it in context

- **A:** Correct - repeatability of "cow" across many animals is explained by the word's relation to cow-ness, with the individual reached as its instance.
- **B:** States the Nyāya position, which takes the qualified individual as primary and treats the universal as its qualifier.
- **C:** States the Buddhist exclusion theory, which Mīmāṃsā rejects because pure negation cannot ground stable positive recognition.
- **D:** States the Grammarian sound-burst theory, which both Mīmāṃsā sub-schools reject as an unnecessary additional entity.

Examiner trap 21: The stem's "or both" is ignored, and the answer caricatures Mīmāṃsā as knowing only universals and Nyāya as knowing only particulars, when the dispute concerns priority alone.

MCQ 22. How authorlessness secures the Veda

Which statement gives the Mīmāṃsā ground for Vedic authority?

A. The Veda is authoritative because an omniscient author cannot err, deceive or forget anything B. The Veda is authoritative because it has no author and so has no locus for defect at all C. The Veda is authoritative because successful ritual results confirm its statements over time D. The Veda is authoritative because its sentences are inferred to be true from the world's order

Answer: B. The Veda is authoritative because it has no author and so has no locus for defect at all

- **A:** States the Nyāya God-guarantee, which Mīmāṃsā rejects because it requires proving existence, then omniscience, then truthfulness in turn.
- **B:** Correct - unreliability in testimony is traced to authorial ignorance, deceit, partiality or forgetfulness, and an authorless text supplies no such locus.
- **C:** Makes validity depend on later confirmation, which is the extrinsic thesis the school refuses on anti-regress grounds.
- **D:** Turns scriptural authority into an inference from cosmic order, which is a design argument Mīmāṃsā uses against theism rather than for scripture.

Examiner trap 22: "Revealed scripture" is glossed as "revealed by God," and the answer installs precisely the personal author whose removal is the whole point of the doctrine.

MCQ 23. Injunction, impelling force and the unseen potency

Which statement correctly reports the Bhāṭṭa analysis of "one desiring heaven should sacrifice"?

A. Verbal impelling force produces the fruit, while objective impelling force produces the impulse B. A single undivided impelling force produces both the impulse and the fruit without any division C. Verbal impelling force produces the impulse, and objective impelling force produces the fruit D. Obligation binds the agent directly, so no impelling force needs to be posited in the sentence

Answer: C. Verbal impelling force produces the impulse, and objective impelling force produces the fruit

- **A:** Exchanges the two results, assigning the fruit to the word and the impulse to the act, which reverses the very distinction the doubling was introduced to draw.
- **B:** Denies the doubling that defines the Bhāṭṭa analysis, whose whole point is that linguistic impelling and real production are different functions.
- **C:** Correct - the sentence impels the qualified agent to undertake the act, and the act performed with proper means produces the result, mediated by unseen potency.
- **D:** States Prabhākara's alternative, in which the directly apprehended to-be-done binds the agent without any two-fold analysis of force.

Examiner trap 23: The two forces are memorised as a pair of Sanskrit terms without their two results, so the candidate can name them but cannot say which one reaches heaven.

MCQ 24. Atheism inside an orthodox school

Which statement best expresses why Mīmāṃsā's rejection of a creator God is consistent with its defence of the Veda?

A. Because the school treats the Veda as a human composition whose value lies in its antiquity B. Because scriptural authority is grounded in impersonality, which divine authorship would destroy C. Because the ritual deities are denied altogether, leaving the sacrifice as the only reality D. Because the school accepts a creator for cosmology while denying him any role in scripture

Answer: B. Because scriptural authority is grounded in impersonality, which divine authorship would destroy

- **A:** Mīmāṃsā denies human composition as firmly as divine composition, and antiquity is not among the grounds it offers for authority.
- **B:** Correct - a God-authored Veda would depend on proving that author's competence and sincerity, which is a weaker foundation than authorlessness.
- **C:** Ritual deities are retained as mantra-denoted entities subordinate to the sacrifice; what is denied is their role as creators or dispensers of fruit.
- **D:** The school denies a creator in cosmology too, arguing from a beginningless world, the motive problem and the sufficiency of action and unseen potency.

Examiner trap 24: Atheism is reported as an embarrassing inconsistency in an orthodox school, when the sources present it as a consequence of the very doctrine that makes the school orthodox.

REMEDIAL DRILLS

MCQ 25. Repairing the instrument-count

A learner writes: "Both Mīmāṃsā sub-schools accept six means of valid knowledge, including non-cognition." Which correction is required?

A. None, because the six-item list including non-cognition is common to both sub-schools B. The list must be reduced to four for both, since comparison is not accepted in Mīmāṃsā C. Postulation should be removed from the Prābhākara list while non-cognition is retained D. Prābhākara accepts five and rejects non-cognition as an independent instrument of knowledge

Answer: D. Prābhākara accepts five and rejects non-cognition as an independent instrument of knowledge

- **A:** Endorses the error under repair, and the six-item list belongs to Kumārila's line alone rather than to the school as a whole.
- **B:** Comparison is accepted by both sub-schools and appears in the five-item and six-item lists alike, so the reduction to four is unfounded.
- **C:** Inverts the actual position, since postulation is precisely the instrument Prābhākara does accept and non-cognition the one he refuses.
- **D:** Correct - the single point of difference between the two lists is non-cognition, which Prābhākara explains away by perception of the bare locus.

Examiner trap 25: This is the most frequently repeated factual error in the topic, and it is fatal in any question that names Prābhākara, because it misstates his position in the first line.

MCQ 26. Repairing the two false-cognition theories

A learner writes: "Bhāṭṭa's contrary apprehension is the same as Nyāya's otherwise-apprehension, since both admit a false cognition." Which correction is required?

A. Neither school admits a false cognition, so both descriptions should be replaced by non-discrimination B. Nyāya does not admit a false cognition, and its account should be described as indescribability instead C. Both admit a false cognition, but Bhāṭṭa misidentifies this object while Nyāya displaces a real one D. Bhāṭṭa does not admit a false cognition, since he explains illusion by conflating perception and memory

Answer: C. Both admit a false cognition, but Bhāṭṭa misidentifies this object while Nyāya displaces a real one

- **A:** Non-discrimination is Prābhākara's theory, and applying it to two schools that expressly admit a false cognition erases three positions at once.
- **B:** Indescribability is the Advaita account, and Nyāya's theory turns on a real object presented in the wrong place rather than on indeterminate status.
- **C:** Correct - for Kumārila the shell before the subject is positively miscognised, whereas for Nyāya real silver known elsewhere is presented here.
- **D:** Attributes Prabhākara's non-discrimination to Kumārila, reversing the two Mīmāṃsā theories that the 2022 question requires to be kept apart.

Examiner trap 26: The shared phrase "false cognition" masks a difference of object, and an answer that merges the two theories cannot deliver the four-column comparison examiners look for.

MCQ 27. Repairing the account of Vedic authority

A learner writes: "The Veda is authoritative for Mīmāṃsā because God revealed it to the sages." Which correction is required?

A. The Veda is authorless, and its authority rests on the absence of any locus for authorial defect B. The Veda is authoritative because the sages who received it were verified as reliable witnesses C. The Veda is authoritative because its ritual prescriptions are confirmed by observed results D. The Veda is authoritative because inference from the world's order establishes a truthful author

Answer: A. The Veda is authorless, and its authority rests on the absence of any locus for authorial defect

- **A:** Correct - the school argues from no remembered author, the natural word-meaning relation and the eternality of word-units to a text free of authorial defect.
- **B:** Reintroduces personal authority through the sages, whereas Mīmāṃsā treats reciters and teachers as transmitters rather than as authors or guarantors.
- **C:** Grounds scripture in observed confirmation, which cannot reach a supersensible object and would surrender the school's intrinsic-validity thesis.
- **D:** Restates the design argument that Mīmāṃsā rejects, since the world as a whole is not observed to be manufactured and a bodiless agent cannot be shown to act.

Examiner trap 27: The English phrase "revealed scripture" is imported without examination, and one careless sentence converts the most anti-theistic orthodox school into a theistic one.

MCQ 28. Repairing the two semantic labels

A learner writes: "Prabhākara holds connection-of-the-already-denoted and Kumārila holds denotation-of-the-connected." Which correction is required?

A. Both labels belong to Kumārila, since Prabhākara has no distinctive theory of sentence meaning B. Both labels belong to Prabhākara, since Kumārila treats sentence meaning as indivisible C. Neither label is Mīmāṃsā's, since both were introduced by the Grammarian sound-burst tradition D. The labels are exchanged: word-priority is Kumārila's and connected denotation is Prabhākara's

Answer: D. The labels are exchanged: word-priority is Kumārila's and connected denotation is Prabhākara's

- **A:** Prabhākara's connected-denotation thesis, supported by the learning argument, is one of his most distinctive contributions and cannot be removed.
- **B:** Kumārila does not treat sentence meaning as indivisible; that is the Grammarian view which both sub-schools reject.
- **C:** Both labels are internal Mīmāṃsā terms, and the sound-burst theory is a rival that Mīmāṃsā argues against rather than a source of these theses.
- **D:** Correct - Kumārila's words denote first and are then connected, while Prabhākara's words denote only as already connected in the sentence.

Examiner trap 28: The two compound terms differ by a syllable and are memorised phonetically, so under time pressure the candidate reproduces the pair in whichever order comes first.

MCQ 29. Repairing the self-awareness mechanisms

A learner writes: "Bhāṭṭa explains knowledge of cognition by threefold awareness and Prabhākara by the object's knownness." Which correction is required?

A. Both explanations belong to Nyāya, which alone addresses how a cognition is itself known B. The mechanisms are exchanged: threefold awareness is Prabhākara's and knownness is Kumārila's C. Neither mechanism is needed, since both sub-schools accept the second-order after-cognition D. Both mechanisms belong to Kumārila, who uses threefold awareness for perception and knownness for memory

Answer: B. The mechanisms are exchanged: threefold awareness is Prabhākara's and knownness is Kumārila's

- **A:** Nyāya's own mechanism is the distinct second-order after-cognition, and it defends neither self-luminosity nor inference from knownness.
- **B:** Correct - Prabhākara's single act discloses knower, known and knowing, while Kumārila denies self-luminosity and infers cognition from acquired knownness.
- **C:** The after-cognition is the Nyāya solution that both Mīmāṃsā sub-schools reject, each for its own reasons.
- **D:** Splits one thinker across two incompatible mechanisms and would leave Prabhākara with no account of self-awareness at all.

Examiner trap 29: Because Prabhākara is the economical thinker elsewhere, candidates expect him to hold the inferential account, when economy is exactly what makes him affirm self-luminosity.

MCQ 30. Repairing the claim about inference

A learner writes: "Mīmāṃsā rejects inference, which is why it needs postulation and non-cognition." Which correction is required?

A. Mīmāṃsā rejects inference only in ritual contexts, accepting it freely in ordinary matters B. Mīmāṃsā accepts inference but denies that it can be applied to any supersensible object C. Mīmāṃsā accepts inference fully and rejects only the claim that all mediate knowing is inferential D. Mīmāṃsā accepts inference as its primary instrument and treats perception as derivative from it

Answer: C. Mīmāṃsā accepts inference fully and rejects only the claim that all mediate knowing is inferential

- **A:** No such contextual restriction exists; the school uses standard sign-based inference wherever a concomitance is available, ritual or otherwise.
- **B:** Inference is indeed unable to reach duty, but that is a limitation of its object and not a rejection of the instrument as such.
- **C:** Correct - the school uses smoke and fire in the ordinary way and opposes only reductionism, which is what licenses postulation and non-cognition.
- **D:** Perception is the most basic disclosure of sensible objects, and no Mīmāṃsā text makes inference prior to it.

Examiner trap 30: The existence of two extra instruments is read as hostility to inference, and the answer then contradicts the school's own use of the smoke-and-fire example.

MCQ 31. Repairing the injunction taxonomies

A learner writes: "The three kinds of injunction are the act, its subsidiary application and the qualified agent." Which correction is required?

A. Those belong to a separate coordination grid; the three kinds are novel, restrictive and exclusionary B. Those are correct, but a fourth kind covering performance-order must be added to complete the list C. Those belong to the five-function sentence taxonomy, which also includes mantra and praise passages D. Those belong to the three factors of impelling force, namely result, means and procedure

Answer: A. Those belong to a separate coordination grid; the three kinds are novel, restrictive and exclusionary

- **A:** Correct - the act, subsidiary application, performance-order and qualified agent form a four-part scheme for coordinating a complex rite, not the logical classification of injunctions.
- **B:** Adding performance-order completes the coordination grid but leaves the logical classification of injunctions still unstated.
- **C:** The five-function taxonomy classifies injunction, prohibition, mantra, name and praise passage, and contains none of the four listed items.
- **D:** The three factors answer what is to be brought about, by what means and by what procedure, which is a different scheme again.

Examiner trap 31: Three separate schemes are collapsed into one long list of Sanskrit terms, and the answer then cannot show that Mīmāṃsā's hermeneutics is systematically organised.

MCQ 32. Repairing the account of liberation and the self

A learner writes: "Mīmāṃsā holds one universal self, and liberation is realisation of identity with Brahman." Which correction is required?

A. Mīmāṃsā denies any enduring self, and liberation is the cessation of the momentary series
B. Mīmāṃsā holds many eternal selves, and liberation is release from karmic embodiment and pain
C. Mīmāṃsā holds one universal self, but liberation is granted by God to the qualified agent
D. Mīmāṃsā holds many eternal selves, and liberation is the permanent attainment of heaven by ritual

Answer: B. Mīmāṃsā holds many eternal selves, and liberation is release from karmic embodiment and pain

- **A:** A momentary series is the Buddhist position, and it would destroy the agent-enjoyer identity that ritual responsibility requires.
- **B:** Correct - the school accepts a plurality of eternal selves as knower, agent and enjoyer, and later accounts describe release as the end of fresh merit, demerit and embodiment.
- **C:** Retains the Advaitic single self and adds a divine grant of liberation, importing exactly the creator the school argues against.
- **D:** Confuses the ritual fruit with liberation, whereas heaven is a karmically produced result and release is the cessation of such production.

Examiner trap 32: The liberation doctrine is late and comparatively thin, so candidates fill the gap with whichever neighbouring school they know best, usually Advaita.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Ownership. Mīmāṃsā owns fourteen primary parts in the 2018-2025 Paper I corpus and appears as a primary owner in every year of that window: one part each in 2018, 2019, 2020 and 2021, two each in 2022, 2023 and 2025, and four in 2024. All fourteen are reproduced and solved below.

Status of the model answers. UPSC Mains publishes no official answer key or model answer. Every solution below is independent learner practice written to the stated word band and directive, and it is never presented as an official key.

Declared answer bands. 10 marks: 150-200 words. 15 marks: 250-300 words. 20 marks: 340-400 words. Every solved answer states its exact word count.

VERIFIED PREVIOUS-YEAR QUESTIONS - 14 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018, Question 8(a), 20 marks

Printed question. Does the admission of Svayaṃprakāśavāda necessarily lead to the admission of Svataḥprāmāṇyavāda? Discuss after the Naiyāyikas, the Mīmāṃsakas and the Advaita Vedāntins.

Directive read. "Necessarily" makes this a question about entailment, not about popularity. A survey without a verdict fails; a verdict without the survey is unsupported.

Model answer (398 words).

Self-luminosity (**svayaṃprakāśatva**) asks whether a cognition is manifest without another cognition. Intrinsic validity (**svataḥ-prāmāṇya**) asks whether a cognition is entitled to *prima facie* truth without external certification. Manifestation and truth-entitlement are distinct questions, so no entailment can be read off the definitions; it would have to be argued, and no school argues it.

The Naiyāyikas accept neither thesis. A cognition is known through a distinct later cognition (**anuvyavasāya**) of the form "I know the pot," and validity is ascertained extrinsically through successful activity (**pravṛtti-sāmarthya**) or confirming perception (**saṃvādi-pratyakṣa**). Nyāya is therefore not the awkward case of self-luminosity without intrinsic validity; it simply denies both.

The Mīmāṃsakas divide, and this division decides the question. Prabhākara holds that one cognition discloses knower, known and knowing together (**tripuṭī-saṃvit**), comparing cognition to a lamp that shows itself while showing the room; he also holds intrinsic validity. Kumārila denies self-luminosity: cognition is like a painter who does not paint himself, and its occurrence is inferred from the object's acquired knownness (**jñātātā**). Yet Kumārila is among the strongest defenders of intrinsic validity, arguing that if every cognition needed another to certify it an infinite regress (**anavasthā**) would follow.

Kumārila is therefore the decisive counterexample. A single actual case of intrinsic validity without self-luminosity refutes a claim of necessity. Nor is his combination unstable: cognition is inferred from what it leaves behind in the object, while its truth-entitlement is settled by the anti-regress argument, so the two issues are handled by different machinery.

The Advaita Vedāntins affirm both, but on different ground. Self-luminosity belongs to consciousness as such and not merely to cognitive episodes, while empirical cognition carries *prima facie* authority until sublated within a doctrine of levels of reality. Their pairing is therefore a substantive metaphysical commitment rather than a definitional consequence - which is exactly what the question's word "necessarily" is testing.

The answer is accordingly negative. The two doctrines travel together in Prābhākara and in Advaita, come apart in Bhāṭṭa, and are jointly rejected by Nyāya.

Two qualifications complete the discussion. First, independence is not irrelevance: a self-luminous cognition makes intrinsic validity easier to defend. Second, the standing objection that intrinsic validity cannot explain error is answered on both Mīmāṃsā routes - Prabhākara by admitting no false cognition, Kumārila by tracing falsity to extrinsic defect and later sublation.

The verdict, then, is that manifestation and truth-entitlement are two properties, not one under two names.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2019, Question 5(e), 10 marks

Printed question. How does Mīmāṃsā establish the authority of Vedic knowledge?

Directive read. "How ... establish" asks for the argumentative route, not for the claim. State the mechanism, then one line of critical residue.

Model answer (199 words).

Mīmāṃsā establishes Vedic authority by removing its author. Duty (**dharmā**) is supersensible, and the formula **codanā-lakṣaṇo'rtho dharmah** makes Vedic injunction its distinguishing mark, so verbal testimony is not a fallback but the only competent instrument.

The argument proceeds by subtraction. Unreliability in testimony is traced to authorial defects: an author may err, deceive, be partial or forget. No author of the Veda is remembered, though an author of so momentous a text would have been; the word-meaning relation is natural (**autpattika**) rather than instituted convention; and word-units possess eternality (**śabda-nityatva**), so utterance manifests rather than produces them. A text with no author has no locus for such defect.

This is reinforced by intrinsic validity (**svataḥ-prāmāṇya**): cognition is authoritative on arrival and loses authority only through a defect (**doṣa**) or a defeater (**bādhaka**). Since duty is a domain no rival instrument reaches, no defeater arises there - which also blocks the charge that rival scriptures become equally self-valid, for those have authors and defect-loci.

Against Nyāya's omniscient author, Mīmāṃsā objects that one must prove God's existence, omniscience and truthfulness in turn.

Critically, the defence rests on two contested props: the absence of a remembered author, and the naturalness of word-meaning.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2020, Question 5(c), 10 marks

Printed question. Why is memory not a valid knowledge according to Mīmāṃsā?

Directive read. A "why" question with a single-point answer. The mark lies in giving the correct reason and naming the condition, not in listing memory's defects.

Model answer (200 words).

Memory (**smṛti**) is excluded not because it is unreliable but because it is unoriginal. A means of valid knowledge (**pramāṇa**) is the operative source of a *fresh* true cognition, and memory supplies none.

Prabhākara's argument runs in five steps. An instrument must generate a new cognition of an object; memory depends on an earlier cognition together with its latent impression (**saṃskāra**); it reproduces old content; it does not reveal a new object as presently known; therefore it is not an instrument. The condition it fails is novelty (**anadhigatatva**) - not-already-ascertained.

The distinction must be stated explicitly, because it is what the question tests. Memory may be true. It may be useful. It may guide action successfully. None of this confers instrument-status, because the title tracks novel valid disclosure alone. Seeing a temple now is perception; recalling yesterday's visit is memory, and the latter is not new knowledge of the temple.

Nyāya reaches the same verdict by the same route, treating memory as re-presentation rather than fresh disclosure.

The exclusion is nevertheless a verdict about status, not about irrelevance. Memory remains indispensable within comparison (**upamāna**), within Prabhākara's analysis of error, and within ordinary sentence-comprehension. Only retrieval's claim to the title is denied.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2021, Question 6(c), 15 marks

Printed question. What, according to Mīmāṃsakas, is the ontological status of abhāva (absence) and how does one know it? Explain and examine.

Directive read. Two demands - status and route - plus "examine," which requires the internal disagreement and a graded close.

Model answer (270 words).

For Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā, absence (**abhāva**) is real. It is not a shadow cast by language but a structured content with a counterpositive (**pratiyogin**), the entity whose absence it is; "absence of pot" is therefore an ontological item, and negative cognition has a genuine object.

The route to it is a distinct instrument. Kumārila argues that we do know absences - "there is no pot on the table" - that the cognition is definite and action-guiding, that it is not perception, which yields positive content, not inference, which requires a positive sign, and not memory, comparison or testimony in the typical case. An independent source is therefore required, and that source is non-cognition (**anupalabdhi**): non-apprehension of what would be apprehended if present.

The instrument is tightly limited by fitness (**yogyatā**). The absent object must be perceptible in kind, the locus suitable, the organ functioning, and light, distance and attention proper. Hence "no pot on this lit table" is knowledge, while "no atoms here" is not. This limitation answers the charge of subjectivism and simultaneously defeats the inferential reduction, since treating non-seeing as a sign already presupposes the evidentiary force fitness supplies.

Examining the position, the Mīmāṃsakas do not speak with one voice. Prabhākara holds that what is known is simply the locus as unqualified by the absent object, so no separate instrument is needed. Nyāya accepts absence as real but takes it to be directly perceived - "pot-absence-on-the-floor" - so Nyāya and Prabhākara converge against Bhāṭṭa on independence for different reasons.

The graded verdict is that Kumārila preserves the phenomenology of negative cognition most faithfully while carrying the heaviest ontology, a cost he expressly accepts.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2022, Question 6(c), 15 marks

Printed question. How do Mīmāṃsakas refute the Nyāya view that Implication (arthāpatti) is reducible to Inference (anumāna) and establish Implication as an independent means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)? Critically discuss.

Directive read. Two tasks - refute, then establish - and "critically" demands that the residual Nyāya pressure be recorded.

Model answer (273 words).

Postulation (**arthāpatti**) is the necessary postulation of an unperceived fact to remove an incompatibility (**anupapatti**) between facts already known. Devadatta is stout; he does not eat by day; stoutness cannot stand with total absence of nourishment; therefore night-eating is posited as the minimally reconciling supplement. It is neither perceived here nor remembered.

Nyāya attempts a reduction: fatness is the reason (**hetu**), eating the probandum (**sādhya**), and the concomitance is "whoever is fat eats." Mīmāṃsā refutes this on three independent grounds.

First, no concomitance is independently established. Inference requires **vyāpti** known beforehand, and no prior universal rule about stout day-fasters exists; the cognition arises because the facts would otherwise conflict. Second, the direction of reasoning differs: inference moves from observed sign to unobserved signified, whereas postulation moves from explanatory tension to a reconciling postulate - not "this sign indicates that fact" but "without that postulate, these facts are inexplicable." Third, there is no subject-reason-probandum structure at all; there is a clash of accepted facts and a demanded supplementation.

The reduction is then shown to be circular. The concomitance Nyāya needs is not independently known; if it is claimed as known, it was abstracted from lived cases by exactly the tension-driven move under dispute. The reduction consumes its own conclusion.

Positively, an instrument is admitted wherever reduction fails without remainder, and this cognition is neither sign-based nor positively perceptual - hence its independent standing, accepted by both Mīmāṃsā sub-schools.

Critically, Nyāya can still press that "explanatory necessity" conceals a suppressed general premise. Mīmāṃsā's strongest reply is that its claim is stronger than inference to the best explanation: the postulate is not merely best, but required.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2022, Question 7(a), 20 marks

Printed question. In spite of accepting the intrinsic validity of knowledge, why and how Prabhākara and Kumārila differ in their interpretation of erroneous cognition? Discuss.

Directive read. The "in spite of" clause is the question. The answer must show that the two error-theories are two defences of one shared thesis.

Model answer (393 words).

Both Prabhākara and Kumārila hold that validity is intrinsic and invalidity extrinsic: a cognition is authoritative on arrival, and falsity requires a defect (**doṣa**) and is detected by a defeater (**bādhaka**). Precisely because the thesis is shared, illusion becomes the system's stress-test - and each thinker protects the thesis by protecting a different thing.

Prabhākara defends non-apprehension of difference (**akhyāti**, more precisely **vivekākhyāti**). In the shell-silver case the subject validly perceives *this shining thing*; the subject also validly recalls previously experienced silver; the failure lies in not apprehending the difference between the two. Because of this non-discrimination, the subject reaches for silver. No separate false cognition need be posited. The strategy therefore keeps *every constituent cognition valid*: the presentational cognition is valid, the memory is valid, and error lies only in their conflation.

Kumārila defends contrary apprehension (**viparīta-khyāti**). The shell is before the subject; bad light, distance, similarity of lustre or sensory defect cause it to be miscognised; a single erroneous cognition arises - "this is silver" - and it is false. Its falsity, however, is due to extrinsic defect and not to cognition's normal nature, and it is discovered extrinsically when the subject approaches and sees clearly. The strategy therefore keeps *the principle governing normal cognition*, quarantining falsity in abnormal conditions.

The costs are exactly complementary. Prabhākara must explain the assertive force of "this is silver" by a mere failure of discrimination, and critics reply that non-discrimination underrates the positive character of the judgement. Kumārila must admit a false cognition into a system built on default truth, and critics reply that this grants too much to falsity. Each replies by pointing to the price the other pays: Prabhākara's is a psychological implausibility, Kumārila's an apparent concession, and neither is a surrender of the shared thesis.

Both must also be kept distinct from Nyāya's otherwise-apprehension (**anyathā-khyāti**), in which real silver known elsewhere is presented here, and from Advaita's indescribable appearance (**anirvacanīya-khyāti**), which is neither real nor unreal. The Bhāṭṭa and Nyāya accounts are the pair most often conflated, because both admit a false cognition; the difference is that Kumārila *misidentifies the object present*, whereas Nyāya *misplaces an object known elsewhere*.

The difference between the two Mīmāṃsakas is therefore not a lapse from the shared thesis but two rival strategies for honouring it - one protecting every constituent cognition, the other protecting the principle that governs normal cognition.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2023, Question 6(b), 15 marks

Printed question. Present Bhaṭṭa's view of anupalabdhi (non-cognition) as a valid means of knowledge.

Directive read. "Present" asks for a full, structured exposition: definition, argument, condition, refusals of reduction, rivals, and a closing evaluation.

Model answer (276 words).

Non-cognition (**anupalabdhi**) is, for Kumārila Bhaṭṭa, the independent means of knowing absence through non-apprehension of what would be apprehended if present. It is the sixth instrument by which Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā exceeds Nyāya's four, and it is rejected by Prabhākara, whose list stops at five.

Kumārila's argument is cumulative. We do know absences, such as "there is no pot on the table"; the cognition is definite and action-guiding; it is not ordinary perception, since perception delivers positive content; it is not inference, since inference requires a positive sign; and it is not memory, comparison or testimony in the typical case. An independent source is therefore necessary.

The instrument is disciplined by fitness (**yogyatā**), which is why it is properly called **yogyānupalabdhi**. The absent object must be the kind of thing that would be perceived if present; the locus must be suitable; the organ must function; light, distance and attention must be proper. "No pot on this bare, well-lit table" satisfies these; "no atoms here" does not, because atoms are not perceptible in kind.

Bhāṭṭa refuses both reductions. Perception gives the table, its colour, shape and spread; "absence of pot" is not a positive sensible datum of that kind, so perceiving an empty table is one thing and cognising the pot's absence another. Inference needs a positive sign and known concomitance; offering "not-seeing" as the sign requires explaining why not-seeing has evidentiary force, which already presupposes fitness - so the reduction is strained or circular.

Its object, absence (**abhāva**), is accordingly real, structured by its counterpositive (**pratiyogin**). Kumārila accepts the ontological cost in order to preserve a cognition that everyday life - no chalk, no key, no bus - constantly presupposes.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2023, Question 8(c), 15 marks

Printed question. Do words refer to universals or particulars or both? Present an exposition of Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā position with regard to above question along with suitable examples.

Directive read. The "or both" is a warning against caricature, and examples are demanded explicitly, so at least two must appear.

Model answer (273 words).

Both schools hold that language reaches universals *and* individuals. The dispute is about semantic priority, not coverage, and an answer that caricatures either side misses the question.

Mīmāṃsā holds that a word primarily denotes the universal (**jāti**). The argument is from repeatability: the same word "cow" applies to indefinitely many individual animals, and the most economical explanation of this is the word's relation to cow-ness. The individual is then reached through the universal as instantiated in a concrete context. Thus "cow" can pick out the animal before me because cow-ness is recognisable in it. This coheres with the school's two-stage perception, in which determinate perception - "this is a white moving cow" - interprets what the indeterminate stage implicitly held rather than imposing an unreal predicate.

Nyāya reverses the priority. The primary denotatum is the individual (**vyakti**) as qualified by universal and form, so that the word reaches the qualified particular first and the universal figures as its qualifier.

An objection presses Mīmāṃsā: a universal cannot be milked, brought or sacrificed. The reply distinguishes meaning from application - the universal is primary for meaning, while action reaches the qualified individual through contextual application. This matters ritually, since "bring the cow" must deliver an actual animal.

The sharpest challenge is Buddhist exclusion (**apoha**): no real universal is needed, since "cow" functions by excluding non-cows. Mīmāṃsā replies that pure exclusion cannot explain stable positive recognition and repeatable application unless a shared class-character is already available.

For depth, the Grammarian sound-burst theory (**sphoṭa-vāda**) treats sentence-meaning as an indivisible flash; both Mīmāṃsā sub-schools reject it, holding that eternal phonemes with ordered manifestation, together with expectancy, fitness and proximity, already suffice.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2024, Question 5(d), 10 marks

Printed question. How does Bhaṭṭa's view of nature of word-meaning and sentential-meaning differ from Prabhākara's view? Critically discuss.

Directive read. A ten-mark comparison with a critical tail: shared conditions, the two theses, one objection each, and a verdict.

Model answer (198 words).

Both sub-schools face the problem of sentence-unity (**ekavākyatā**) and accept the same three conditions for it: mutual expectancy (**ākāṅkṣā**), semantic fitness (**yogyatā**) and proximity (**sannidhi**). They differ over which unit is semantically primary.

Kumārila holds connection-of-the-already-denoted (**abhihitānvayavāda**). Each word first denotes its own meaning (**padārtha**) through its denotative power (**abhidhā**); sentence-meaning then arises through a further connecting operation, explained as indirect signification (**lakṣaṇā**) or purport-power (**tātparya-śakti**). The word is primary and sentence-meaning derivative, and the two stages are logical rather than temporal.

Prabhākara holds denotation-of-the-connected (**anvitābhidhānavāda**). Words denote their meanings only as already connected with the other meanings in the sentence. His evidence is the learning situation (**vyutpatti**): a child hears an elder command "bring the cow," sees a younger person comply, and learns the words in their connected, action-guiding sense.

Critically, each is charged with what the other explains. Kumārila is charged with positing an unobserved isolated-word stage and an extra operation in every sentence; he replies that the distinction is explanatory, not introspective. Prabhākara is charged with making a word mean differently in every sentence; he replies that recurrent connected uses yield stable competence.

The verdict is complementary: Bhaṭṭa secures stable lexical meaning, Prabhākara contextual action-guidance.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2024, Question 8(a), 20 marks

Printed question. How do I know that I know? Answer this question with reference to the Naiyāyikas, the Bhaṭṭa Mīmāṃsakas and the Prabhākaras.

Directive read. Three named columns. The mark-difference lies in naming the shared problem - regress - and showing that all three are engineered answers to it.

Model answer (384 words).

The question is not psychological but structural. If a cognition is not manifest in itself, another cognition must reveal it; that one needs a third; and an infinite regress (**anavasthā**) follows. Every classical answer is a device for stopping this regress, and the three schools stop it at different places.

The Prabhākaras stop it immediately. Cognition is self-luminous (**svaprakāśa**), and a single act discloses knower, known and knowing together - threefold awareness (**tripuṭi-saṃvit**). The lamp analogy carries the point: a lamp reveals itself while revealing the room, and needs no second lamp. Reflective statements such as "I know that I know" are later conceptual articulations of what was already manifest pre-reflectively. Objection: does simultaneous revelation confuse the three? Reply: they are disclosed together, not ontologically collapsed. There is no metacognitive gap.

The Bhaṭṭa Mīmāṃsakas deny self-luminosity. An object, once cognised, acquires a new relational status - knownness (**jñātatā**); observing that status, we infer that a cognition has occurred. Cognition is like a painter who paints objects but not himself, and its occurrence is established by what it leaves behind in the object. Objection: knownness looks like a mysterious posit. Reply: Kumārila accepts that cost rather than the stronger thesis of self-luminosity. The consequence is a temporal and logical gap: I know first, and I know that I know afterwards, inferentially.

The Naiyāyikas stop the regress by permitting exactly one further act. A distinct second-order cognition (**anuvyavasāya**) takes the first as its object, in the form "I know the pot." This is neither self-luminosity nor inference from knownness. Objection: does the second-order act not restart the regress? Reply: Nyāya treats it as sufficient without endless repetition.

The three positions are thus best ranked by the gap they tolerate - none, inferential, reflective - and each gap carries a matching cost: the risk of conflating the three items disclosed together, the positing of an obscure relational property, and the reappearance of the regress the higher-order act was meant to halt. Each school has an answer to its own cost, so the dispute is unresolved rather than won.

What can be asserted confidently is narrower and more useful. Kumārila's combination of non-self-luminous cognition with intrinsic validity is philosophically stable, and it shows that knowing-that-one-knows and being-entitled-to-believe are separate questions: manifestation is settled by knownness and inference, truth-entitlement by the anti-regress argument.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2024, Question 8(b), 15 marks

Printed question. "A candidate who is never seen to be studying during the day time secures a high position in a competitive exam." How would the Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsakas and the Naiyāyikas explain the success of this candidate? Discuss.

Directive read. An applied case requiring *both* explanations to be written out, then compared. Stating only the Mīmāṃsā account answers half the question.

Model answer (285 words).

The Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsakas explain the case by postulation (**arthāpatti**). Two facts are accepted: the candidate tops the examination, and the candidate is never seen studying by day. Examination success is incompatible with no preparation at all, so the two facts generate explanatory tension. To let both stand, some unobserved preparation must be posited, and the minimally reconciling postulate is study at night or otherwise outside observed daytime. The night-study is neither perceived here nor remembered; it is postulated because otherwise the accepted data remain inexplicable. This is postulation from perceived facts (**dr̥ṣṭārthāpatti**), structurally identical to the canonical case of stout Devadatta who does not eat by day.

The Naiyāyikas frame the same case as an inference. Wherever there is examination success there is preparation; this candidate has examination success; therefore this candidate had preparation. The reason (**hetu**) is success, the probandum (**sādhya**) is preparation, and the transition runs through a concomitance (**vyāpti**).

The Bhāṭṭa reply is that the reduction misses what actually generates the cognition. The reasoning does not begin from a sign but from a clash of accepted facts; the movement is from explanatory tension to a reconciling postulate rather than from sign to signified; and the case shows no subject-reason-probandum structure. Above all, the concomitance is slipped in too quickly: "wherever there is success there is preparation" is not independently established, and if it is claimed as known, it was abstracted from lived cases by exactly the postulating move under dispute. The reduction is therefore circular.

Discussion should end even-handedly. Nyāya's account is simpler and keeps the instrument-list short; the Bhāṭṭa account is more faithful to how the cognition actually arises, which is why Mīmāṃsā treats explanatory necessity as epistemically basic.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2024, Question 8(c), 15 marks

Printed question. On what grounds do the Prābhākaras and the Naiyāyikas reject memory as a source of knowledge? Discuss.

Directive read. "On what grounds" and two named schools: give the shared ground, show the convergence explicitly, and mark what the exclusion does not claim.

Model answer (277 words).

Both schools reject memory (**smṛti**) on a single shared ground: an instrument of valid knowledge must produce a *fresh* cognition, and memory produces none. The technical name of the failed condition is novelty (**anadhigatatva**) - not-already-ascertained.

Prabhākara's argument runs in five steps. A means of valid knowledge (**pramāṇa**) must generate a new cognition of an object. Memory depends on an earlier cognition together with its latent impression (**saṃskāra**). It reproduces old content. It does not reveal a new object as presently known. Therefore it is not an instrument.

The Naiyāyikas reach the identical verdict by the identical route: memory presents what was already known, and is re-presentation rather than fresh disclosure. This convergence is philosophically notable, since the two schools are opposed on almost everything else in epistemology - intrinsic versus extrinsic validity, non-discrimination versus displacement in error, self-luminosity versus the second-order after-cognition. That they agree here shows that the exclusion follows from the definition of an instrument rather than from any school-specific commitment.

Three clarifications are essential. First, the ground is not unreliability: memory may be true, useful and successfully action-guiding, and none of this confers instrument-status. Second, the exclusion is definitional, which is its strength - it concedes everything a defender of memory might want to say while denying only the title. Third, it is a verdict about status and not about irrelevance, since memory remains indispensable within comparison (**upamāna**), within Prabhākara's own analysis of error, and within ordinary sentence-comprehension.

Discussion may note the cost: because the exclusion turns on a definition, a rival could contest the definition itself. The standing reply is that it is not arbitrary, since it tracks a real difference between disclosing and retrieving.

Solved PYQ 13 - 2025, Question 5(c), 10 marks

Printed question. Delineate the main points of difference between the theory of intrinsic validation (svataḥ prāmāṇyavāda) and theory of extrinsic validation (parataḥ prāmāṇyavāda) in classical Indian philosophy.

Directive read. "Delineate the main points of difference" wants discrete contrasts; "in classical Indian philosophy" wants more than two schools.

Model answer (200 words).

The two theories divide on four cells, not one. Intrinsic validation, held by Mīmāṃsā, treats both the origin (**utpatti**) and the ascertainment (**jñapti**) of validity as intrinsic: the conditions that generate a cognition generate its validity, and the cognition presents itself as trustworthy unaided. Invalidity, by contrast, is extrinsic in both respects, arising from a defect (**doṣa**) and becoming known through a defeater (**bādhaka**), contradiction or practical failure. Extrinsic validation, held by Nyāya, treats both the origin and the ascertainment of validity as extrinsic relative to the mere occurrence of the cognition.

The points of difference follow. First, burden of proof: Mīmāṃsā places it on the challenger, Nyāya on the cognition. Second, mechanism: Nyāya certifies by successful activity (**pravṛtti-sāmarthya**) or confirming perception (**saṃvādi-pratyakṣa**), while Mīmāṃsā denies that later success can generate validity. Third, regress: a validating cognition would itself need validation, producing **anavasthā**. Fourth, the decisive distinction: validity itself versus our ascertainment of it.

Placed more widely, Sāṃkhya is presented as intrinsic on both counts, and Buddhist epistemology as the mirror-image, extrinsic validity with intrinsic invalidity - which Mīmāṃsā rejects, since illusion does not announce itself as illusion.

The essential qualification is that intrinsic validity is *defeasible default warrant*, not infallibility.

Solved PYQ 14 - 2025, Question 6(c), 15 marks

Printed question. Discuss the debate between the Bhaṭṭa and the Prabhākara mīmāṃsakas with reference to the nature of Non-existence (Abhāva) and its knowledge.

Directive read. An *internal* Mīmāṃsā debate. Answering it as Mīmāṃsā versus Nyāya is off-target, though Nyāya may enter as a comparison.

Model answer (296 words).

The debate is intra-Mīmāṃsā and runs on two connected questions: what absence (**abhāva**) is, and how it is known.

Kumārila Bhaṭṭa treats absence as real. It is not a feature of language but a structured content determined by its counterpositive (**pratiyogin**), so that "absence of pot" has genuine ontological standing and negative cognition has a genuine object. Correspondingly, he admits a sixth instrument, non-cognition (**anupalabdhi**), defined as non-apprehension of what would be apprehended if present and limited by fitness (**yogyatā**): the object must be perceptible in kind, the locus suitable, the organ functioning, and light, distance and attention proper.

His reasons are two refusals. Perception yields positive content - table, colour, shape - whereas "absence of pot" is not a positive datum of that kind, so perceiving the empty table is not yet cognising the pot's absence. Inference needs a positive sign and a known concomitance; if "not-seeing" is offered as the sign, its evidentiary force already presupposes non-apprehension under fit conditions, so the reduction is strained or circular.

Prabhākara declines both the ontology and the instrument. What is known, he holds, is simply the locus as unqualified by the absent object: we perceive the table as bare, not as occupied by the pot, and the bare-locus cognition already carries the negative differentiation required. No special faculty for what is not there need be posited. His position is an economy thesis, not a denial that absences are known. Kumārila's counter is that economy purchased by flattening a determinate negative judgement into a positive perception is false economy.

For comparison, Nyāya converges with Prabhākara against Kumārila on independence while diverging in its reason, since it holds that absence is itself directly perceived. The graded verdict is that Kumārila is the more faithful phenomenologist and Prabhākara the more economical metaphysician.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

These six questions are written in the style and directive-vocabulary of the paper. They are original practice items, not previous-year questions.

Original 1 - 10 marks

Question. Explain why Mīmāṃsā treats Vedic testimony as the only competent means of knowing dharma rather than as a source of last resort. Answer in about 175 words.

Model answer (172 words).

In most systems testimony is a convenience: it saves labour where perception or inference could in principle have done the work. In Mīmāṃsā it is nothing of the kind, and the difference follows from the object rather than from any preference for scripture.

Duty (**dharma**) is supersensible. It is not a present sensible object, so perception is structurally disqualified. It is not reached by any sign standing in a known concomitance with it, so inference is disqualified too. The school's defining formula makes this explicit: duty is that whose distinguishing mark is Vedic injunction - **codanā-lakṣaṇo'rtho dharmah**.

An instrument is individuated in Mīmāṃsā by the manner in which it generates cognition, and matched to the kind of object it can disclose. Since only verbal testimony can disclose an object of this kind, testimony here is not second-best; it is the sole competent witness.

Two consequences follow. Vedic testimony must be impersonal, since a human speaker would import defect. And its authority must be intrinsic, since no external certifier for a supersensible domain exists.

Original 2 - 10 marks

Question. Discuss the significance of the claim that non-cognition operates only under conditions of fitness. Answer in about 175 words.

Model answer (168 words).

The fitness condition (**yogyatā**) is not a technical footnote to non-cognition (**anupalabdhi**) but the clause that makes the doctrine defensible, and its significance is threefold.

First, it converts a non-event into evidence. Non-apprehension is informative only where the conditional holds that the object *would* have been apprehended if present: the thing must be perceptible in kind, the locus suitable, the organ functioning, and light, distance and attention proper. "No pot on this bare, well-lit table" satisfies this; "no atoms here" does not.

Second, it answers the standing objection that non-perception is too subjective. Careless overlooking is excluded by the same clause that admits genuine absence-cognition, so the instrument cannot be used to license an argument from ignorance.

Third, it defeats the inferential reduction. If "not-seeing" is offered as a positive sign, one must explain why not-seeing carries evidentiary force - and that force is exactly what fitness supplies. The reduction therefore presupposes the doctrine it was meant to replace.

Fitness thus does simultaneous work as definition, defence and refutation.

Original 3 - 15 marks

Question. Examine the view that Mīmāṃsā's rejection of a creator God strengthens rather than weakens its defence of the Veda. Answer in about 275 words.

Model answer (283 words).

The view is well founded, though it must be stated with two qualifications.

The strengthening argument is straightforward. Mīmāṃsā grounds Vedic authority in authorlessness (**apauruṣeyatva**): unreliability in testimony is traced to authorial defects - error, deceit, partiality, forgetfulness - and a text with no author has no locus for them. If God authored the Veda, the Veda would have an author, and its authority would then depend on establishing that author's existence, omniscience and truthfulness. Nyāya's three-stage burden is exactly this. By removing the author entirely, Mīmāṃsā removes the burden, and the text becomes self-valid in the domain of duty, where no rival instrument supplies a defeater.

The rejection is also independently argued rather than merely convenient. God is not perceptually given; the inference from world to maker fails, since pots are observed to be made by embodied artisans while worlds are not observed to be made by bodiless creators; a beginning of creation raises an unanswerable question about divine motive; and moral order is already regulated by action, merit, demerit and unseen potency (**apūrva**). Against the demand for a giver of karmic fruits, the decisive move is a dilemma: a God who distributes strictly by karma is redundant, and one who distributes otherwise is partial.

The first qualification is that the deities of ritual are not abolished. They remain mantra-denoted entities to whom offerings are made, subordinate to the sacrifice, with the fruit produced by act and unseen potency rather than by divine favour.

The second is that the strengthening is internal. Critics who find an unconscious potency less intelligible than a conscious Lord are unmoved, and it remains genuinely contested whether the atheism is a considered metaphysics or a by-product of exegetical necessity.

Original 4 - 15 marks

Question. Critically discuss whether Mīmāṃsā's theory of intrinsic validity can be defended without collapsing into credulity. Answer in about 275 words.

Model answer (285 words).

The charge of credulity is the most persistent objection to intrinsic validity (**svataḥ-prāmāṇya**), and the defence succeeds only partially.

The doctrine is that a cognition is valid by its own occurrence under normal conditions, while invalidity requires a defect (**doṣa**) and is disclosed by a defeater (**bādhaka**). Three considerations support it. The regress argument: if every cognition required another for validation, the validator would need a validator, generating **anavasthā**. The argument from practice: crossing a road, reading a page or obeying an instruction presupposes immediate trust, and no first action could be launched if certification came first. And economy: doubt is parasitic on a more basic trust.

Against credulity, the school makes two further moves. It insists that the thesis is defeasible default warrant and not infallibilism, so correction is welcomed rather than resisted. And it presupposes realism - cognitions are directed at real objects and normal causes tend toward truth - which prevents the doctrine from reducing to mere self-certification by the mind.

The dream and mirage objection is met by distinguishing the appearance of normalcy from normalcy itself: exhaustion and sleep in one case, heated air and optical distortion in the other, are extrinsic defects, so these cognitions do not arise from fully normal truth-producing conditions.

Critically, however, the reply relocates the difficulty rather than dissolving it. Everything now turns on identifying a genuine defect, and Nyāya can press that "abnormal conditions" is a label applied retrospectively whenever a cognition proves false. Whether the doctrine escapes circularity or merely shifts it into the notions of defect and defeater is genuinely contested.

The defensible verdict is that intrinsic validity avoids credulity in principle, provided defect is independently specifiable - which is precisely the point still under dispute.

Original 5 - 20 marks

Question. Analyse the claim that Mīmāṃsā's philosophy of language is shaped throughout by the requirement that an authorless text must be able to command. Answer in about 375 words.

Model answer (368 words).

The claim is largely correct, and tracing it explains why Mīmāṃsā's semantics takes the unusual shape it does.

Begin with the requirement. The Veda is authorless (**apauruṣeyatva**), and its central function is injunction (**vidhi / codanā**). A text with no speaker must therefore generate obligation out of its own structure. Every major semantic doctrine of the school can be read as a condition of that possibility.

First, sentence-unity. Obligation is carried by sentences, not by words, so the school must explain how a word-sequence yields one cognition (**ekavākyatā**). Both sub-schools accept expectancy (**ākāṅkṣā**), fitness (**yogyatā**) and proximity (**sannidhi**) as the conditions of that unity.

Second, the treatment of purport. Naiyāyikas add purport (**tātparya**), the speaker's intended thrust. Mīmāṃsā cannot use it, because there is no speaker; purport must be relocated into textual force, contextual unity and subordination to injunction. This is a direct consequence of the requirement.

Third, the two rival semantics. Kumāṛila's connection-of-the-already-denoted secures stable lexical meaning across contexts, which an eternal text needs if its words are not to shift with usage. Prabhākara's denotation-of-the-connected, supported by the learning argument (**vyutpatti**), secures that words are grasped in action-guiding wholes - which fits an injunction-centred scripture even more snugly.

Fourth, the theory of injunctive force. Kumāṛila locates imperative force in verbal impelling force (**śābdī bhāvanā**), whose result is the agent's impulse, distinguished from objective productive force (**ārthī bhāvanā**), whose result is the fruit; Prabhākara locates bindingness in the directly apprehended to-be-done (**niyoga**). Both answers exist because the command must issue from the sentence rather than from a commander.

Fifth, the eternal word and the rejection of the sound-burst. If word-units are eternal and merely manifested by utterance, the text does not depend on temporal composition; and the Grammarian sound-burst is rejected because phonemes with ordered manifestation already suffice.

Two qualifications are needed. The shaping is not total: the universal-particular dispute has its own motivations in the theory of perception and in the debate with Buddhist exclusion. And the requirement generates the school's most

contested commitments - the naturalness of word-meaning and the eternality of the word - which Nyāya and the Dharmakīrti line both deny.

The claim is therefore best stated as strong explanatory pressure rather than as complete determination.

Original 6 - 20 marks

Question. Evaluate Mīmāṃsā's expansion of the list of means of valid knowledge to six, with reference to postulation, non-cognition and the exclusion of memory. Answer in about 375 words.

Model answer (372 words).

The expansion is principled rather than promiscuous, but it is not uniformly successful, and the evaluation must be graded.

The governing rule is irreducibility: an instrument is admitted only where a type of knowledge cannot be reduced to another without remainder or without circularity. Perception handles the directly given, inference the sign-based, testimony the verbally transmitted, comparison the resemblance-based. The question is whether two further kinds of cognition resist all four.

Postulation (**arthāpatti**) has the stronger case, and both sub-schools accept it. Stout Devadatta who does not eat by day yields night-eating, not through a sign but through explanatory tension. Three arguments block reduction to inference: no concomitance (**vyāpti**) is independently established; the movement runs from tension to reconciling postulate rather than from sign to signified; and there is no subject-reason-probandum structure. The Nyāya reduction is further shown to be circular, since the concomitance it needs is itself abstracted from postulating moves. The claim is also stronger than modern inference to the best explanation: the postulate is required, not merely preferred.

Non-cognition (**anupalabdhi**) is the harder case, and only Kumārila accepts it. Its strength is phenomenological: "there is no pot on the table" is definite and action-guiding, and reducing it to perception of a bare locus flattens a negative judgement into a positive one. Its discipline is the fitness condition (**yogyatā**), which excludes careless overlooking and imperceptible objects alike. Its cost is ontological, since absence (**abhāva**) must be real and structured by a counterpositive (**pratiyogin**) - a cost Prabhākara and Nyāya both refuse, converging against Bhāṭṭa on independence while diverging in their reasons.

The exclusion of memory shows that the rule cuts both ways. Memory reproduces already-cognised content and fails the novelty condition (**anadhigatatva**), so it is denied instrument-status even though it may be true, useful and action-guiding - and Nyāya agrees. A school that merely wished to inflate its list would not have exercised this restraint.

The graded verdict is therefore that the expansion is defensible in method and unequal in result. Postulation is Mīmāṃsā's most robust epistemological contribution; non-cognition is its most faithful and most expensive; and the exclusion of memory is the clearest evidence that the school's longer list is the product of a rule rather than of appetite.